

The Gol is Just Not That Into

FREEDOM

The ministries and babus of the Indian government departments are all heading towards the road to slavery.

Different agencies of the Indian government seem to be making all the wrong moves lately. Two issues have come to our notice and both are quite disturbing. These issues not only raise questions over how such national bodies discriminate against free software alternatives, but also reveal how they are forcing people to use non-free or proprietary software sold by big corporations.

The irony is, while one government organisation endorses proprietary software, the other releases software that is even more restrictive than those sold by their commercial counterparts. The two organisations in question are Technology Development for Indian Languages (TDIL), established by the Department of Information Technology (DIT), and the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO).

Fonts: Can't read the free word

The apex body of the DIT recently finalised the fonts to be used for e-governance related work. While the apex body approved Unicode 5.1.0 as a standard for e-governance applications for all 22 Indian languages, except for Kashmiri, it chose a font that is not free software compliant.

The font approved is Sakal Bharti, which has been jointly developed by TDIL and CDAC. But the font itself is not 'free' in nature. If you go to the TDIL site to download the font approved by the apex body, you will be greeted by a disclaimer that forces you to agree to certain terms if you want to download it. I, as an individual or a company, ought to have the full freedom to download and use anything that has been developed by using taxpayers' money. The owners of such technologies should be the citizens